everything from repeated compliments to keeping silence on the issue to art books full of conical-breasted Eighteenth Century milkmaids holding lambs in the pasture. One night they got Carvel cones after a movie. He finished his first, and when he looked up at Doreen's soft swirled chocolate-vanilla cone it had been licked into *exactly* the shape of one of her breasts; and he leaned over and kissed the ice cream, so that when he came up again and mildly smiled at her with melted ice cream on his lips she did not laugh as he had hoped but burst into tears.

The sun intensified, then waned as a cloud came over it, making Miro's vision swim a little with relief. Up here in the country things looked *blue* when the sun left suddenly like that; it had happened on the road a few times. A ribbed metal monster lay behind a thicket of white, flat flowers; they grew more sparsely in between the tines of its enormous spreaded fork, shaking in the breeze while it slowly rusted away.

With Rhoda, at least, he had been able to relax. She had no wounds to tend to, or at least none that she brought to him with tears in her face the way Doreen would. In fact, after six years of therapy Rhoda already knew so much about herself there was little need for him. They screwed, they cooked, they went to the movies. But having no evident problems of her own, Rhoda's interest in Miro's rocky welfare came to seem patronizing. He'd get back from work tied up in knots with the effort and the guilt of continuous deceit, open the apartment door and feel his other, *home* self gush into his body like a cold ghost. Then Rhoda would ask clumsy questions like "what's the matter, Hon, no sales?" No, that was *not* the problem.

Of course that was the problem *sometimes*; every salesman has a certain number of dud days waiting to happen. But most often Miro's troubles were those of the crackerjack, who blew it all wide open—lied, invented, improvised and charmed his way into closing after closing and thus moved the merch like a freight train—but then had to live with himself. Few guys could even do this; and of those few, most had no problem with it but Miro, the best, ate himself up so that he popped Tums all day and had to drink ginger ale everywhere he went, to calm his stomach. Miro imagined conversations in which he and Rhoda talked all this out; he imagined himself sitting in a chair with her standing behind him and touching his shoulders, pleading with him to quit the job. But she did no such thing; and the closest she came was buying him more ginger ale.

Rhoda would never realize all this; she had her ideas about romance, and nothing was going to dislodge them. In her mother's kitchen Miro once heard her mother's half of a phone conversation with their pastor, in which the woman talked of Miro as if he weren't in the room at all, though he stood in plain sight. "He's a very handsome boy," she said, and "boy" was infuriating enough—boys don't make a Grand a week— "and he treats Rhoda just like a doll!" But he did not pamper Rhoda or show her off like a doll, and this hint from her mother helped prove what he'd been trying not to believe: that she *wanted* that doll stuff. Rhoda told Miro that he was handsome so often he began to suspect that might be why she wanted him in the first place, and why she stayed with him. Once they'd known each other for a few weeks, Rhoda would do anything in bed, anything he wanted; but she never remembered those things, so he had to tell her over again every time—in their bed, no idiom developed. Even after four months together, there were no games, no pet names, none of the informal and homespun crap he had expected and waited for and wanted. Instead her love came out in storebought gifts and these awful, fawning cards she sent him through the mail—though he lived down the street from her. And you could not fight with her: he'd try to get her going, and she would look up from her *Mademoiselle* and quip, "I don't care—You can say whatever you want." When she bought him a birthday cake with the legend "Happy Birthday Handsome," he immediately put his fist right through it without realizing what he was doing. They broke up a week later.

The sun had risen a few hands higher, and though his car had stopped leaking steam out of the hood, he wanted to stay. It was cool here, in the shade of the clouds, though he could see the hot sun on the next field and in patches up and down the green mountains at the horizon. Miro bent down and admired a cricket in the bowl formed by wild dandelion fronds, and the cricket leapt onto the loud yellow flower in the middle, making it sway. Walking further on he found a bunch of joints, like little boomerangs with holes for bolts that had fallen out or been salvaged when they were still good. Corroded wing-nuts littered the spot.

What a dish Doreen was, that day Frank Cohen brought her to the shop: she was his cousin, he said; they had played miniature golf together when they were both nine. After Frank went out to move the merch, Doreen sauntered around the shop, cooing over the hammers and the wrenches and the pliers in a voice that made Miro want to bite her. She returned an hour later for his break and they had a soda in the luncheonette; something about this sweatered girl made him behave as though they were actually in one of the Archie comics she had obviously grown up on. Doreen ate it up.